system (as opposed to 59 percent in other Latin American cities).[21] When asked to identify the biggest problem in Cuba, 42.5 percent chose "low salaries, high cost of living," while only 18.2 percent chose "lack of freedoms, political system." The largest proportion (42 percent) gave no answer to the question of what kind of government would best solve their country's problems. Only 32.1 percent believed that a democratic form of government would be the best solution.[22]

People in Latin America tend to be more ambivalent about democracy than those in the United States. In almost every country, significant majorities view the role of the United States in the world as "mainly negative." Overall, the majority approves of democracy, but these are often slim majorities: in Mexico 54 percent believed that democracy was the best form of government; in Colombia, 53 percent; and in Brazil, only 46 percent.[23] By large majorities, Latin Americans preferred socialism to capitalism in a 2008 Gallup poll. Only in two countries, Mexico and Panama, did slightly more people prefer capitalism. "Any U.S. policy toward Latin America," Gallup concluded, "needs to recognize that 'socialism' is not a dirty word in the region."[24]

Clearly, a huge gap in knowledge, beliefs, and attitudes exists between the United States and Latin America. One of the keys to understanding why is the Cuban Revolution.

This book engages with multiple perspectives in writing a history of the Cuban Revolution. It looks at the positions of policymakers and the media in the United States and Cuba, as well as at popular opinion and popular movements in Cuba and beyond. It brings in the views of a variety of historians and other scholars who have approached the Cuban Revolution with a variety of assumptions and a variety of questions. Most of all, it tries to illuminate the experiences and actions of Cuban people from many different walks of life and what the Cuban Revolution meant for them.

It is also, inevitably, informed by my own perspective. As a scholar who has traveled numerous times to Cuba, including taking three groups of students there as part of a class I teach on the Cuban Revolution, I am a strong opponent of U.S.-imposed travel restrictions. As a Latin